



The milk you make for your baby is **uniquely tailored** to meet all his **nutritional needs** for about the first six months, and provide **immunity protection** at birth and beyond. The composition of this dynamic fluid constantly adapts and changes to give your baby **exactly what he needs** at each stage of his development.

Breast-feeding

Tailor-made nutrition

From the moment your baby is born, your breasts are primed to feed him, first with the pre-milk colostrum made during pregnancy and ready for your baby right away, and then, after about three days, with your breast milk. The production of breast milk is triggered by a surge in the hormone prolactin at birth.

Your milk production works on a supply-and-demand basis, so each time your baby breast-feeds, your breasts are stimulated to produce more milk for his next feeding. During growth spurts, your breasts respond to increased sucking by producing a greater quantity of milk, and in this way, your baby grows and thrives. Even if you manage only a handful of feedings in the first few days, your baby will receive concentrated nutrients and immunity-boosting antibodies that can't be obtained from formula, and that will give him the best possible start.

Benefits for you and your baby

In addition to being free and nutritionally perfect, countless breast-feeding studies point to health benefits. Breast-fed babies have fewer ear, chest, and gastrointestinal infections in the first year, and later on a lower incidence of childhood obesity and diabetes. Breast-feeding is thought to offer some protection against childhood eczema, and

there are fewer incidents of Sudden Infant Death Syndrome (SIDS) in breast-fed babies. Several studies have looked at the link between breast-fed babies and higher IQs. Studies have found that breast-fed babies do better at school and beyond, regardless of wealth or class, which may be due to the high number of special fatty acids in breast milk that promote healthy neural development.

Moms also benefit from breast-feeding, often losing weight more quickly since breast-feeding burns additional calories, and the oxytocin released during breast-feeding helps the uterus contract after birth. Breast-feeding moms are also less likely to develop postpartum depression, or in the long-term, breast, ovarian, and endometrial cancers, or osteoporosis.

Getting started

Although breast-feeding is a natural process, it does not necessarily come naturally to new moms. It takes time and practice to perfect, and it can feel uncomfortable at first. Advice and support can make a real difference, so take advantage of any help provided by the hospital, and ask a breast-feeding consultant for advice when you're back home. You will soon find that you get better at reading your baby's hunger cues, which makes the feeding experience calmer and easier.